

Center for Latin American Folklore: Digital Library Plan

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The Center for Latin American Folklore located at the University of New York, Queens is a special collections digital library located within the university library system that is solely committed to the study, research, and collection of Latin American folklore. The center's mission is the study and conservation of Latin American folklore as a way of learning about, appreciating and preserving Latin American culture and the way it has shaped communities. As of now the Center for Latin American Folklore mainly focuses on the oral and written traditions of storytelling but hopes to eventually acquire collections focused on the arts of music and dance.

Patrons

The digital library serves all members of the University of New York, Queens but is primarily utilized by faculty and students within the Sociology, Literature, and Latin American Studies departments. Undergraduate students in the Latin American Studies department are introduced to the digital library through their curriculum and must utilize it for one of their class projects to help them learn to navigate a digital library and explore the collection itself. Graduate and faculty members use the Center for Latin American Folklore for much deeper research purposes. They regularly interact with both the digital library and the librarians who maintain it to help form and shape their research and scholarly work. Outside researchers who specialize in the study of Latin American culture and folklore can also request access to certain parts of the digital repository, mostly the collection that the

university owns and controls. As the university-controlled collections grow, we expect a wider variety of researchers who will want to gain access.

Library Resources

The Center for Latin American Folklore as a special collection digital library, contains a mixture of resources that cover the scope of learning about and understanding Latin American folklore and where it fits into the wider scope of Latin American culture as a whole. These resources include a collection of oral folktales, periodicals, and e-books. All of these digital resources work towards supporting the center's mission statement and serving the specific academic and research needs of the patrons.

Oral Folktales Collection

The collection of oral folktales was created as a university research project by Dr. Mariana Enriquez who is the head of the Latin American Studies department. As a tenured professor who has to produce published scholarly work, she turned to the Latin American community of Queens to capture the oral folktales of members from all aspects of the Latin American diaspora to preserve a vital form culture that is passed down but so rarely recorded. When the project was complete it only made sense for the Center for Latin American Folklore to acquire the oral folktales as a collection to preserve it and provide wider access. The digital library acquired both the audio recordings as well as the transcripts, and any notes both born digital and digitized. Because the university owns the rights, this collection is the part of the library that is shared with researchers outside of the

institution. By acquiring this collection of oral folktales, the library now provides an example of primary source folklore research to conduct further research from.

Periodicals

The special collection digital library also includes access to multiple e-journals for members of the university. These periodicals serve as academic and theoretically focused scholarly works that explore the culture specific meaning of folklore in communities and culture. Some of the many digital journals that the Center for Latin American Folklore provides access to are the Journal of Latin American Lore, the Journal of American Folklore, Fabula, the Journal of Folklore and Education, Folklore Americano, and the Journal of Folklore Research. The Journal of Latin American Lore was established in 1975 and is published by the UCLA Latin American Center. The journal focuses on the cultural representations of Latin American communities through the use of lore (UCLA Latin American Institute, n.d.). The Journal of American Folklore is a journal of the American Folklore Society founded in 1888 and is published by the University of Illinois Press. Unlike its title suggests, the journal focuses on folklore from around the world and covers past and present folklore scholarship (University of Illinois Press, n.d.). Fabula is a peer reviewed journal that refers to itself as “an international medium of discussion for all issues relevant to historical and comparative folk narrative research” (De Gruyter Brill, 2026). It was established in 1958 and is published quarterly by De Gruyter in multiple languages. The Journal of Folklore and Education is an open access journal published by Local Learning: The National Network for Folk Arts in Education. The journal takes an educational focused ethnographical approach to folklore and cultural stewardship (Journal of Folklore and

Education, 2026). Folklore Americano is a journal published by the Pan American Institute of Geography and History. This journal is a Spanish publication that ran from 1953 to 2002 and explores regional folklore traditions (ProQuest, n.d.). The Journal of Folklore Research was first published as the Journal of the Folklore Institute in 1964. It is published by the Indiana University Press and provides a space for international research on folk culture (Indiana University Press, 2026).

E-Books

The digital repository also provides access to a variety of academically focused e-books that all explore concepts of Latin American folklore from various regions and identities. *A Pre-Columbian Bestiary: Fantastic Creatures of Indigenous Latin America* written by Ilan Stavans, illustrated by Eko, and published by Penn State University Press is an encyclopedic collection of Latin American mythical creatures (Stavans, 2020). *The Latin American story finder: a guide to 470 tales from Mexico, Central America and South America, listing subjects and sources* was written by Sharon Barcan Elswit and published in 2015 by McFarland. It contains English retellings of stories from Central America, South America, and Mexico from a variety of sources (Elswit, 2015). *El Monte: Notes on the Religions, Magic, and Folklore of the Black and Creole People of Cuba* written by Lydia Cabrera was first published in Cuba in 1954. It was translated to English by David Font-Navarrete and published by Duke University Press in 2023. It focuses specifically on Afro-Cuban cultural and religious traditions (Cabrera, 2023). *Curanderismo: Mexican American Folk Healing* by Robert Trotter and Juan Antonio Chavira was published in 1997 by the University of Georgia of Georgia Press. It covers the cultural importance of Mexican

American folk medicine (Trotter & Chavira, 1997). *Songs My Mother Sang to Me: An Oral History of Mexican American Women*, written by Patricia Preciado Martin and published by The University of Arizona Press in 1992 details the accounts of oral history of Hispanic women in the Southwest (Martin, 1992). *Folklore and literature: studies in the Portuguese, Brazilian, Sephardic, and Hispanic oral traditions* by Manuel da Costa Fontes, published in 2000 by SUNY Press examines the way modern folklore adds to the understanding of oral traditions (Fuentes, 2000). *Creating Our Own: Folklore, Performance, and Identity in Cuzco, Peru* by Zoila S. Mendoza and published by Duke University Press in 2008 specifically looks at the development of folkloric arts in Cuzco, Peru and how they have shaped an understanding of regional identity (Mendoza, 2008). *Literary folklore of the Hispanic Southwest* by Aurora Lucero-White Lea, published in 1953 by Naylor Company is a collection of folktales and songs collected from New Mexico to highlight regional heritage (Lea, 1953). *Pachamama tales : folklore from Argentina, Bolivia, Chile, Paraguay, Peru, and Uruguay* by Paula Martin published by Bloomsbury Publishing in 2014 is a collection of folktales accompanied by historical and geographical context (Martin, 2014). *Latin American Folktales: Stories from Hispanic and Indian Traditions* by John Bierhorst, published by New York: Knopf Doubleday Publishing in 2007 combines medieval European and pre-Columbia folktale traditions to show how themes within Latino folklore have been shaped (Bierhorst, 2007).

Library System

The Center for Latin American Folklore uses Ex Libris Alma as its resource management solution. Ex Libris Alma was chosen specifically because of the unique

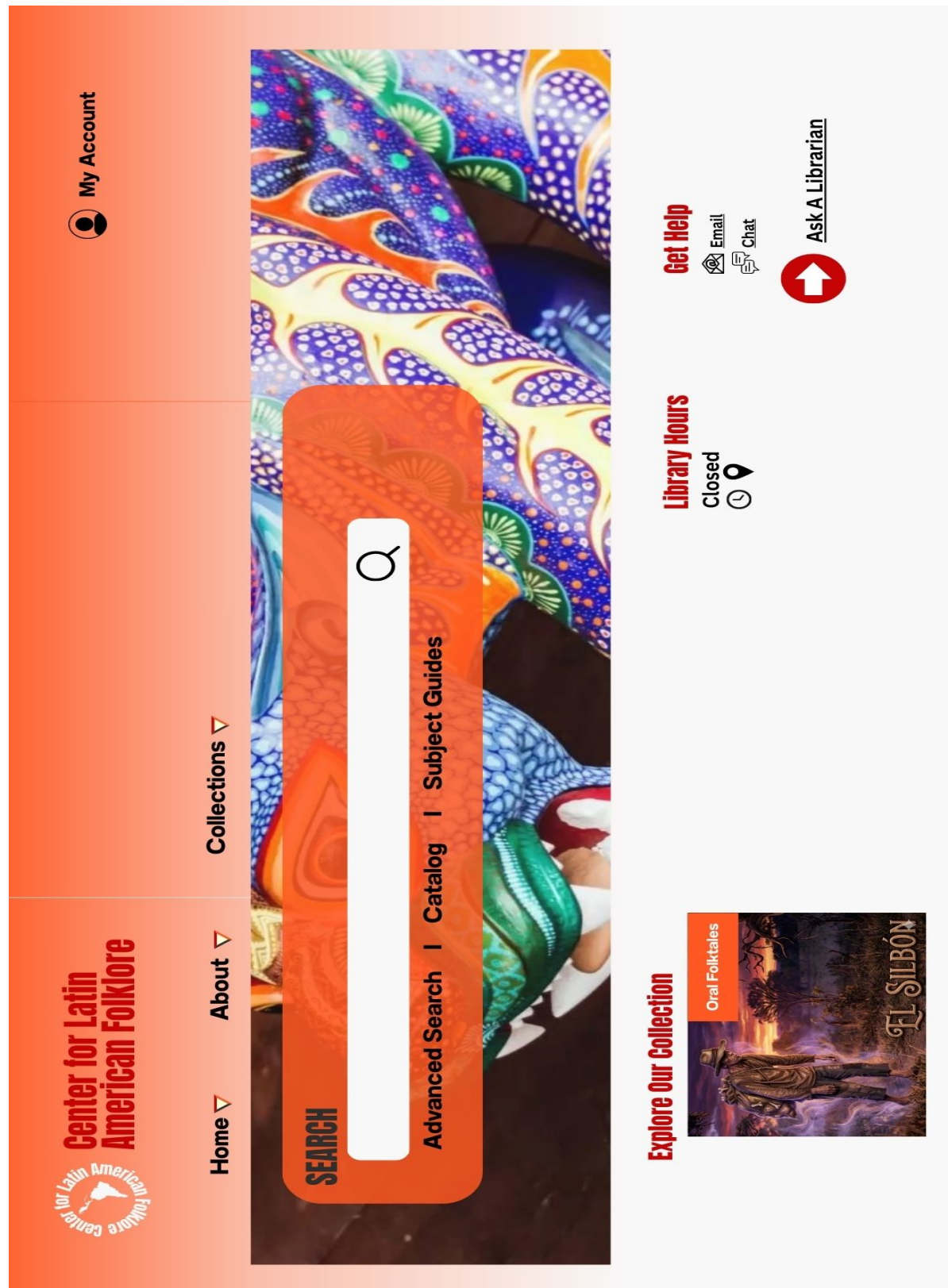
material management that is needed to host both the oral folktales collection as well as provide immediate access to purchased academic journals and e-books. Other explored library systems tended to lean towards more basic library specific needs, or solely archival needs, but as a special collections digital library at a research university, the system used must be able to handle both general library and archival preservation needs. Alma manages all these needs within a single platform, removing unnecessary silos when accessing unique materials (Ex Libris, n.d.). Because of this, users are able to use the same search functions within the site to pull up resources of similar topics across e-books, journals, and the digital collection. Ex Libris Alma also allows users to see quick access previews of materials as part of its search results. On the librarian side, Alma allows for metadata editing, report generation and resource sharing (Ex Libris, from Clarivate, 2022).

Metadata

As a member of a larger university library system, The Center for Latin American Folklore uses both MARC 21 and MODS as metadata schemas. MARC 21 is used primarily to support bibliographic metadata needs like providing descriptions for the journals and e-books within the repository. Most libraries systems are designed around MARC records which allow for easy record sharing and copy cataloguing saving time from having to create these records from scratch (Fritz & Fritz, 2003). One of the pros of using the MARC 21 schema is that it captures extensive information on a very granular level because of the number of fields and tags, meaning that there is a lot of control over the metadata (OCLC, 2026). However, the metadata needs of the oral folktale collection are much different as it operates as archival material. MARC 21 can be rigid and hard to apply to the need for

flexibility with digital records and their metadata and that's why the library decided to use MODS. It's more detailed than Dublin Core and was developed to help translate catalogue information based on MARC to better suit digital systems (Veridian, 2026). Because many MODS elements are closely aligned with MARC fields, is it MARC compatible. "The need for a rich metadata standard such as MODS has been expressed by members of the digital library and related communities as they attempt to implement projects involving search and retrieval, management of complex digital objects, integrating metadata from library databases with other non-MARC sources and other functions" (Guenther & McCallum, 2003, pp. 13). There are cons to having a repository that uses both MARC 21 and MODS. One major con is that the digital library is managing two schemas at the same time, and the schemas don't map across seamlessly. If metadata needs to be moved from MARC 21 to MODs which is simpler, some tagging may be lost. This also means that mapping doesn't necessarily work going the other direction. MODS to MARC 21 might not contain the level of detail the MARC 21 metadata needs for optimal searchability (Guenther & McCallum, 2003).

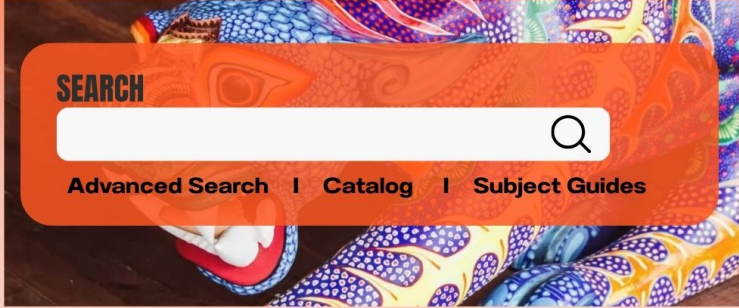
Desktop Interface



Mobile Interface

**Center for Latin American Folklore**

 **My Account** 



SEARCH

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Explore Our Collection



Oral Folktales

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